

## UPSC PHILOSOPHY OPTIONAL

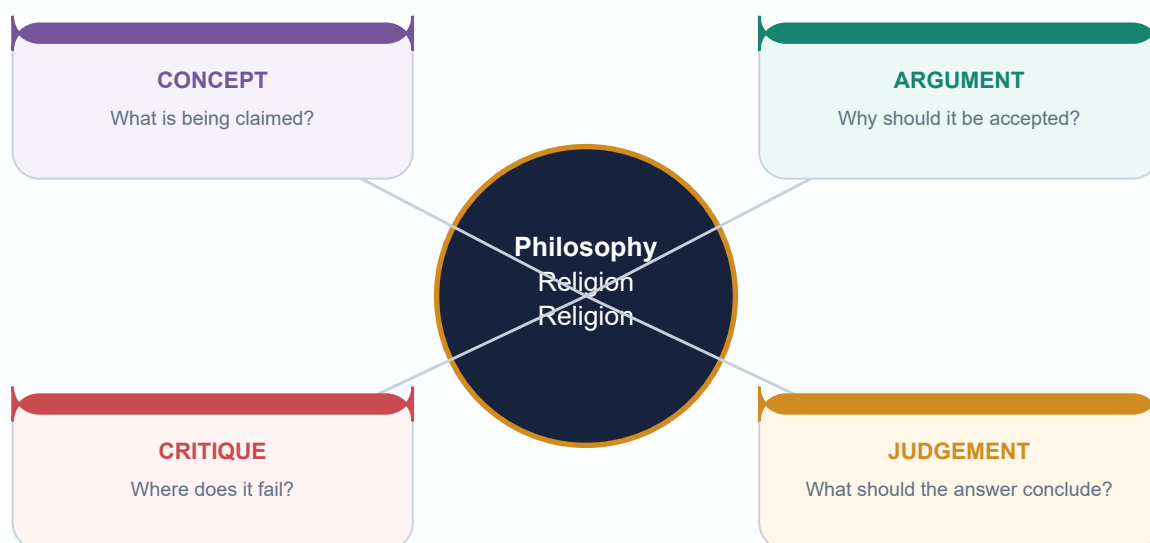
# Philosophy of Religion: Religion without God

UPSC Philosophy Optional | Paper II | Philosophy of Religion

Syllabus: Religion without God.

Direct local-PDF base: Oxford Handbook, Nontheistic Conceptions of the Divine (PDF pp. 71-91); John Hick's typology and critiques in local PDF pp. 16, 41-49 and 116; C. D. Sharma, Buddhism, Jainism, Samkhya and Mimamsa chapters. Cross-check: verified Paper-II knowledge note and verbatim 2022-2025 PYQ bank. The local corpus is stronger on Buddhism and classical critiques than on contemporary secular-religion movements.

Content-rich visual edition: arguments, matrices, Indian perspectives, PYQs and answer frameworks



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

## HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

## Functional Map: Can Religion Exist without a Creator?

Paper II  
Philosophy

## INTRO &amp; ORIGIN

A creator deity is neither logically nor historically necessary for religion. Buddhism, Jainism and Mimamsa organise ethics, practice, community and liberation around Dharma, karma or an ultimate goal rather than divine creation.

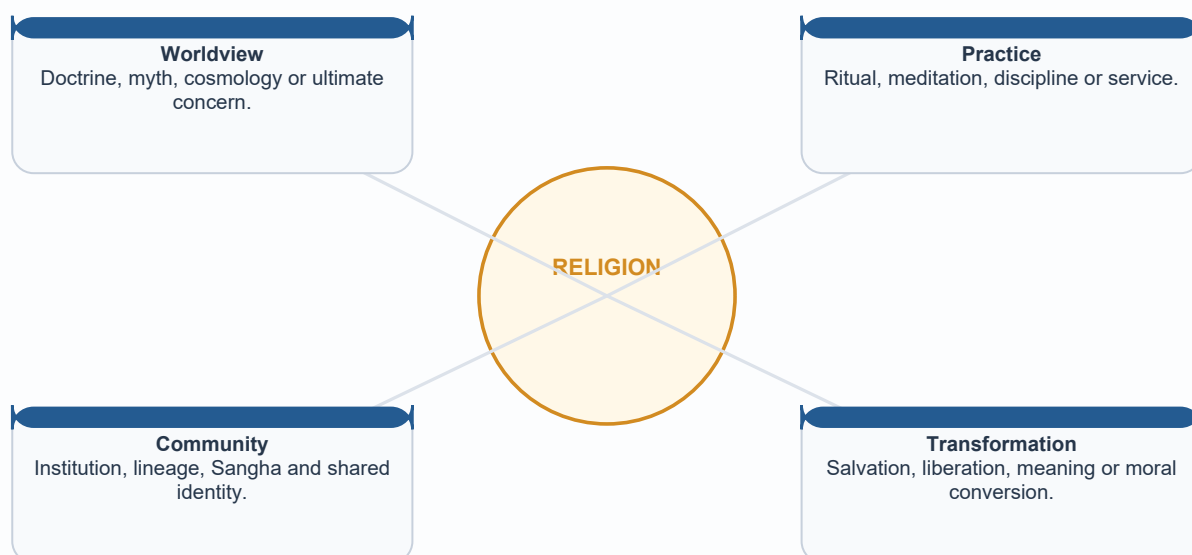
*Direct local-PDF base: Oxford Handbook, Nontheistic Conceptions of the Divine (PDF pp. 71-91); John Hick's typology and critiques in local PDF pp. 16, 41-49 and 116; C. D. Sharma, Buddhism, Jainism, Samkhya and Mimamsa chapters.*  
*Cross-check: verified Paper-II knowledge note and verbatim 2022-2025 PYQ bank. The local corpus is stronger on Buddhism and classical critiques than on contemporary secular-religion movements.*

## WHAT REPLACES GOD?

## ULTIMATE ORIENTATION WITHOUT A CREATOR DEITY

|                                                                               |                                                                                                              |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Buddhism</b><br>Dharma, dependent origination, Sangha and nirvana.         | <b>Jainism</b><br>Plural jivas, karma, Tirthankaras and liberation.                                          |
| <b>Mimamsa</b><br>Authorless Veda, dharma and self-operating ritual efficacy. | <b>Samkhya</b><br>Purusa-prakrti dualism without necessary creator.                                          |
| <b>Humanism</b><br>Human dignity, ethical community and ultimate concern.     | <b>Agnostic Religiosity</b><br>Suspends judgement on God while retaining ethical or experiential dimensions. |

## MINIMUM DIMENSIONS OF RELIGION



## STATIC THEORY

- **Substantive definition:** religion is belief in supernatural beings; this makes God-like entities central but risks excluding Buddhism.
- **Functional definition:** religion orients life to ultimate meaning and transformation; this permits non-theistic traditions.
- **Family-resemblance approach:** doctrine, ritual, ethics, experience and community cluster without one necessary essence.
- **Buddhist case:** dependent origination and karma explain suffering and rebirth without a first creator.

## MEMORY HOOK

**D-D-D: Discipline, Dharma, Deliverance. These can structure religion without deity.**

## MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Non-theistic is not the same as anti-religious or materialist.
2. The Buddha's practical silence on speculative questions differs from dogmatic atheism.
3. Buddhism contains ethics, ritual, community, doctrine and liberation without creator-theism.
4. Jainism reveres liberated teachers without making them creators.

## UPSC TRAPS

**WRONG:** Religion without God means religion without anything ultimate.

**CORRECT:** Dharma, nirvana, liberation or humanity may function as ultimate orientation.

**WRONG:** Buddhism is simply atheism.

**CORRECT:** It is non-theistic and soteriological, not merely denial of God.

## SYLLABUS AND CONCEPT LINKS

| Core Concept        | Linked Debate              | Answer Use                                                   |
|---------------------|----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| Buddhist non-theism | Soul and liberation        | Rebirth and nirvana occur without creator or permanent self. |
| Nietzsche           | Religion and morality      | God's death destabilises inherited moral authority.          |
| Humanism            | Socio-political philosophy | Connect secularism and ethical community.                    |
| Mimamsa             | Reason and revelation      | Authorless Veda gives authority without divine author.       |

## MAINS ANGLE

*God is sufficient for many religions but not necessary for religion as disciplined orientation to ultimate transformation.*

## STUDY LINK

Religion without God.

HIGH

## Core Concepts, Vocabulary and Internal Logic

Paper II  
Philosophy

## INTRO & ORIGIN

The argument depends on definitions of religion and on the completeness of non-theistic examples.

*Definitions are followed by the argument's premises and conclusion so that the doctrine can be reconstructed rather than merely named.*

**KEY DATA**

| Term / Position       | Precise Meaning                                                   | Exam Use                     |
|-----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------|
| Non-theism            | A religious structure without a creator God.                      | Buddhism/Jainism.            |
| Atheism               | Denial or absence of belief in God.                               | Distinguish from non-theism. |
| Agnosticism           | Suspension because God's existence is unknown or unknowable.      | 2023 route.                  |
| Dependent origination | Phenomena arise conditionally without first cause.                | Buddhist cosmology.          |
| Nirvana               | Cessation of craving and suffering.                               | Non-theistic ultimate.       |
| Dharma                | Teaching, norm or path ordering religious life.                   | What replaces command.       |
| Functional definition | Religion understood through meaning, practice and transformation. | Conceptual defence.          |

**BUDDHISM AS A COMPLETE NON-THEISTIC RELIGION****STATIC THEORY**

- **Buddhist completeness:** Four Noble Truths supply diagnosis, cause, cure and path; no explanatory gap requires a creator.
- **Jaina route:** liberated Tirthankaras are exemplars and teachers, while karma operates in a beginningless cosmos.
- **Mimamsa route:** Vedic authority and ritual dharma do not need a divine author or cosmic creator.
- **Agnostic route:** one may participate in ethical and experiential religion while suspending metaphysical assent.

**MEMORY HOOK**

**DIAGNOSIS -> PATH -> COMMUNITY -> LIBERATION: the non-theistic completeness test.**

**MUST-KNOW FACTS**

1. Agnosticism suspends knowledge claims; atheism denies or lacks belief in God.
2. Nietzsche's 'God is dead' diagnoses collapse of a value-world and the threat of nihilism.
3. Humanism can perform ethical and communal functions associated with religion.

**UPSC TRAPS**

**WRONG:** Agnosticism and atheism are synonyms.

**CORRECT:** Agnosticism concerns knowledge; atheism concerns belief or denial.

**WRONG:** Nietzsche merely celebrates unbelief.

**CORRECT:** He diagnoses nihilism and demands revaluation after the collapse of God-grounded values.

**MAINS ANGLE**

*Buddhism is decisive because it removes God without removing the religious problem, path or goal.*

**STUDY LINK**

Use this card for definition, exposition and premise-conclusion reconstruction.

**HIGH****Classical, Contemporary and Indian Perspectives**Paper II  
Philosophy**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Non-theistic traditions differ sharply from modern critiques that seek to dissolve religion itself.

*The comparison matrix keeps similarities and differences on the same axes; Indian positions are included where they alter the structure of the debate.*

**KEY DATA**

| Position         | Attitude to God                                 | Religious / Ethical Replacement                   |
|------------------|-------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| Buddhism         | Creator unnecessary; speculative silence.       | Dharma, Sangha, karma, nirvana.                   |
| Jainism          | No creator; perfected liberated beings revered. | Jiva purification and karmic release.             |
| Mimamsa          | No divine author needed.                        | Authorless Veda and ritual dharma.                |
| Agnosticism      | Knowledge suspended.                            | Ethical or experiential participation may remain. |
| Nietzsche        | God-belief loses credibility.                   | Creative revaluation and self-overcoming.         |
| Secular humanism | Human-centred naturalism.                       | Dignity, reason, solidarity and flourishing.      |

**STATIC THEORY**

- **Feuerbach/Freud/Marx:** religion is projection, illusion or ideological consolation; these critiques explain religion naturalistically.
- **Nietzsche:** Christian morality is read as life-denying slave morality rooted in resentment.
- **Contemporary issue:** functional definitions risk making nationalism or sport into religion unless ultimacy and transformation are specified.

**MEMORY HOOK**

**NON-THEISM** retains religion; **CRITIQUE** explains religion away; **HUMANISM** reconstructs value.

**MUST-KNOW FACTS**

1. A religion can be non-theistic yet contain supernatural cosmology.
2. Nietzsche's alternative is not simple permissiveness but value creation.
3. Family resemblance avoids one necessary essence but needs boundary criteria.

**UPSC TRAPS**

- WRONG:** Calling Jain Tirthankaras gods who create.
- CORRECT:** They are perfected liberated teachers, not creators.
- WRONG:** Using Comte or humanism to erase differences from Buddhism.
- CORRECT:** Secular ethical community and soteriological tradition are not identical.

**CROSS-PAPER ENRICHMENT**

| Paper-II Theme        | Paper-I / Indian Link    | Value Added                                  |
|-----------------------|--------------------------|----------------------------------------------|
| Dependent origination | Buddhism                 | Use conditionality instead of a first cause. |
| Authorless Veda       | Mimamsa                  | Religion and norm without divine authorship. |
| God is dead           | Existentialism/Nietzsche | Connect nihilism and revaluation.            |

**MAINS ANGLE**

*Non-theistic religion is coherent, but an over-broad functional definition must still distinguish religion from any intense commitment.*

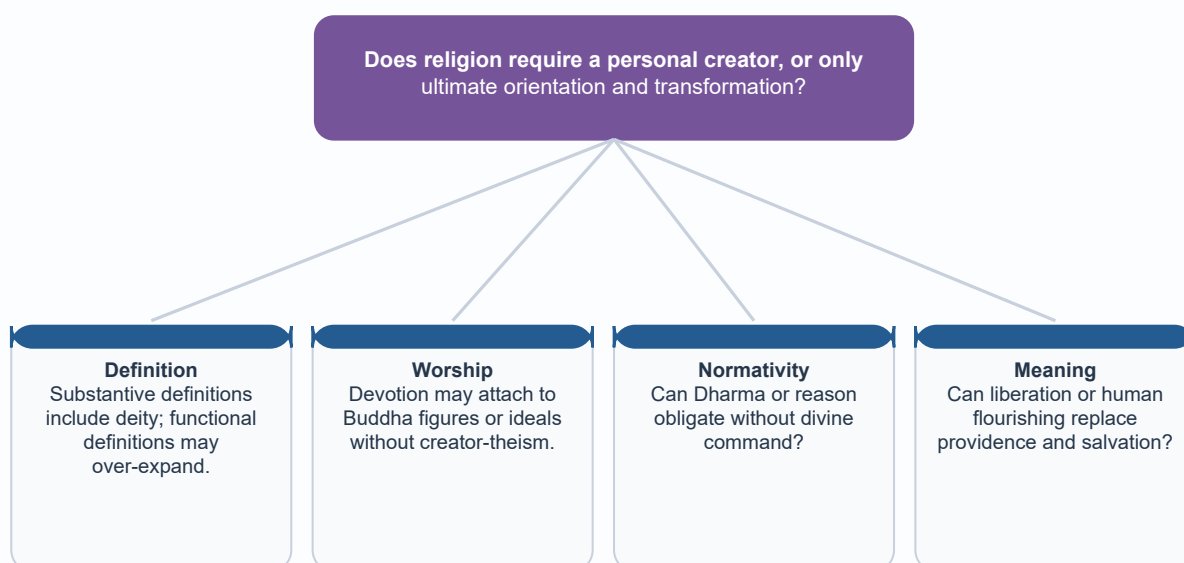
**STUDY LINK**

Deploy one Western and one Indian comparison only when it sharpens the question.

**HIGH****Objections, Replies and Qualified Assessment**Paper II  
Philosophy**INTRO & ORIGIN**

The debate concerns definition, ultimacy, worship and whether non-theistic traditions covertly reinstall divine functions.

*A strong answer presents the strongest objection in its best form, then tests the reply without treating either side as automatically decisive.*

**IS GOD FUNCTIONALLY NECESSARY?**

## KEY DATA

| Objection                                  | Reply / Qualification                                                  | Final Assessment                                                         |
|--------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Without God it is philosophy, not religion | Ritual, community, sacred narrative and liberation exceed theory.      | Buddhism satisfies a robust family-resemblance account.                  |
| Buddhas become functional gods             | Reverence does not entail creatorhood or omnipotence.                  | Later devotional forms qualify but do not erase foundational non-theism. |
| No God means no moral obligation           | Karma, compassion, reason and human flourishing ground norms.          | Motivation and metaphysical grounding remain separate issues.            |
| Functional definition is too broad         | Require ultimacy, comprehensive practice and transformative community. | Boundary remains porous but manageable.                                  |
| Nietzsche leads to nihilism                | He treats nihilism as danger and calls for revaluation.                | His positive ethics remains contested and elitist.                       |

## STATIC THEORY

- **Necessary-condition test:** one clear counterexample is enough to disprove that creator belief is necessary.
- **Completeness test:** a non-theistic religion must explain worldview, practice, community, norm and goal.
- **Normative test:** religion without God shifts, rather than removes, questions of authority and obligation.

## MEMORY HOOK

**COUNTEREXAMPLE + COMPLETENESS = the core argument.**

## MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The concept of sacred need not name a personal being.
2. Non-theistic religion can still contain transcendence, ritual and salvation-language.
3. Agnostic practice and doctrinal non-theism are distinct.

## UPSC TRAPS

**WRONG:** Using Buddhism only as a one-line counterexample.

**CORRECT:** Show diagnosis, path, community and liberation.

**WRONG:** Assuming secularisation eliminates ultimate concern.

**CORRECT:** Ultimate orientation may survive in non-theistic forms.

## MAINS ANGLE

*The category is philosophically stable when religion is defined by comprehensive transformative orientation, not creator belief alone.*

## STUDY LINK

Write criticism as a debate: objection, defence, residual difficulty.

HIGH

## Verified PYQs and Applied Drills

Paper II  
Philosophy

## INTRO &amp; ORIGIN

The following routes reproduce the verified demand of UPSC Philosophy Optional Paper II, Section B. Drills convert recurring formulations into practice prompts.

*PYQ wording and marks are cross-checked against the local 2022-2025 question-paper PDFs and the verified \_PYQ-PhilosophyOfReligion-2022-2025.md bank.*

## KEY DATA

| Year / Marks | Verified PYQ Route                                                 | Core Demand                                    |
|--------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| 2023 / 10    | What is Agnosticism, and how do agnostics relate religion and God? | Knowledge suspension and possible religiosity. |
| 2024 / 20    | State and evaluate Buddhism as a religion without God.             | Completeness of non-theistic religion.         |
| 2025 / 10    | Present Nietzsche's criticism of religion and morality.            | God's death, slave morality and revaluation.   |

## STATIC THEORY

- **Applied drill 1:** Does devotion to Buddha undermine Buddhist non-theism?
- **Applied drill 2:** Can a purely secular humanism count as religion?
- **Applied drill 3:** Compare agnostic religiosity with Mimamsa's non-creator orthodoxy.
- **Applied drill 4:** Does religion require worship or only transformation?

## MEMORY HOOK

Read the directive first: **discuss = balanced exposition; examine = test the claim; critically evaluate = objection, reply and judgement.**

## MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Use the exact syllabus vocabulary in the introduction.
2. Distinguish exposition from evaluation with explicit transitions.
3. A statement question must first interpret the statement's philosophical assumption.
4. Never invent quotations; paraphrase unless wording is securely verified.

## UPSC TRAPS

**WRONG:** Listing thinkers without reconstructing their reasons.

**CORRECT:** Build at least one explicit premise-conclusion chain.

**WRONG:** Using Indian material as an ornamental final paragraph.

**CORRECT:** Integrate it where it changes the conceptual issue.

## MAINS ANGLE

Use Buddhism as a developed counterexample, then distinguish non-theism, atheism and agnosticism.

## STUDY LINK

Revise the PYQ rows alongside the doctrine and dialectic cards.

HIGH

## 10/15/20-Mark Answer Frameworks

Paper II  
Philosophy

## INTRO &amp; ORIGIN

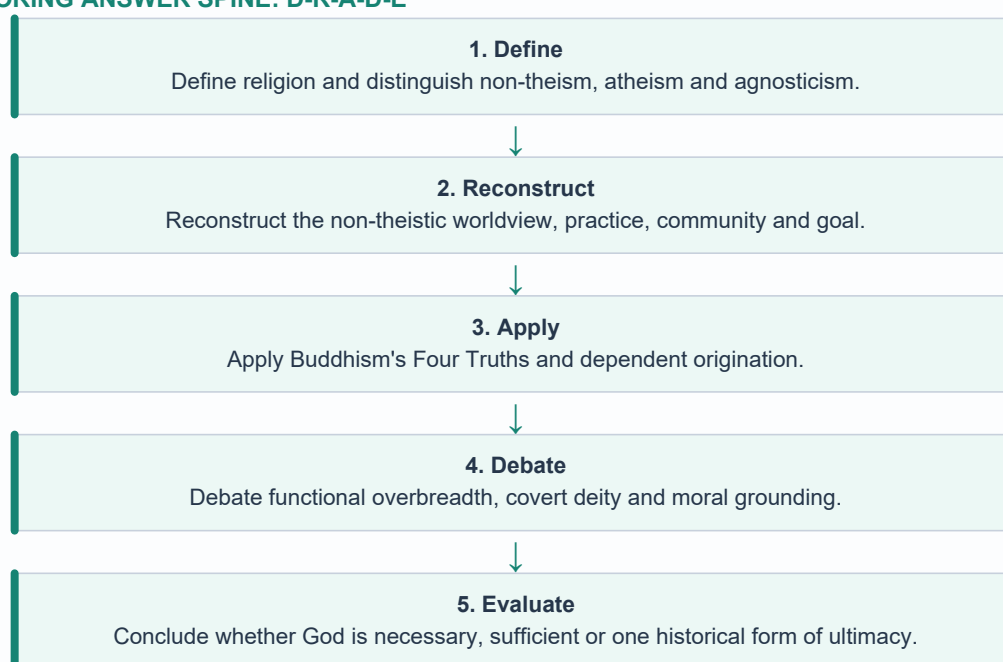
Answer length changes the depth of reconstruction and debate, not the accuracy of the doctrine. Every framework follows Define-Reconstruct-Apply-Debate-Evaluate.

*These are answer architectures, not model answers to memorise verbatim.*



**KEY DATA**

| Marks | Recommended Architecture                                                                                                             | Non-Negotiable                                                 |
|-------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| 10    | Define the relevant category; distinguish nearby terms; use one complete example; add a qualification.                               | One precise distinction and one criticism.                     |
| 15    | Set competing definitions; reconstruct a non-theistic system; compare critique or humanism; judge boundaries.                        | Internal logic, comparison and qualified judgement.            |
| 20    | Use family-resemblance analysis; develop Buddhism fully; add Jain/Mimamsa and Western critique; assess norm, worship and liberation. | Full dialectic, Indian-Western bridge and defended conclusion. |

**HIGH-SCORING ANSWER SPINE: D-R-A-D-E****STATIC THEORY**

- **Buddhist close:** no creator, yet a complete diagnosis-path-liberation structure.
- **Nietzsche close:** death of God creates a value crisis, not an automatic solution.
- **Definition close:** family resemblance is stronger than a deity-only essence.

**MEMORY HOOK**

Conclude: Creator-belief is not necessary because \_\_\_\_ supplies worldview, norm, practice and \_\_\_\_.

**MUST-KNOW FACTS**

1. 10 marks: approximately 150 words; prioritise precision over range.
2. 15 marks: add one comparison and a developed objection-reply.
3. 20 marks: organise the answer around a philosophical problem, not a catalogue.
4. The conclusion must answer the exact necessity, possibility or truth claim asked.

**UPSC TRAPS**

**WRONG:** Giving the same compressed answer for every mark value.

**CORRECT:** Increase depth of reconstruction, criticism and synthesis with marks.

**WRONG:** Ending with 'both views are important'.

**CORRECT:** State what survives criticism and under what qualification.

**MAINS ANGLE**

*God is sufficient for many religions but not necessary for religion as disciplined orientation to ultimate transformation.*

**STUDY LINK**

Final revision: master map -> argument -> comparison -> objection/reply -> PYQ answer spine.

End of Register Notes — UPSC Agent / Copilot CLI